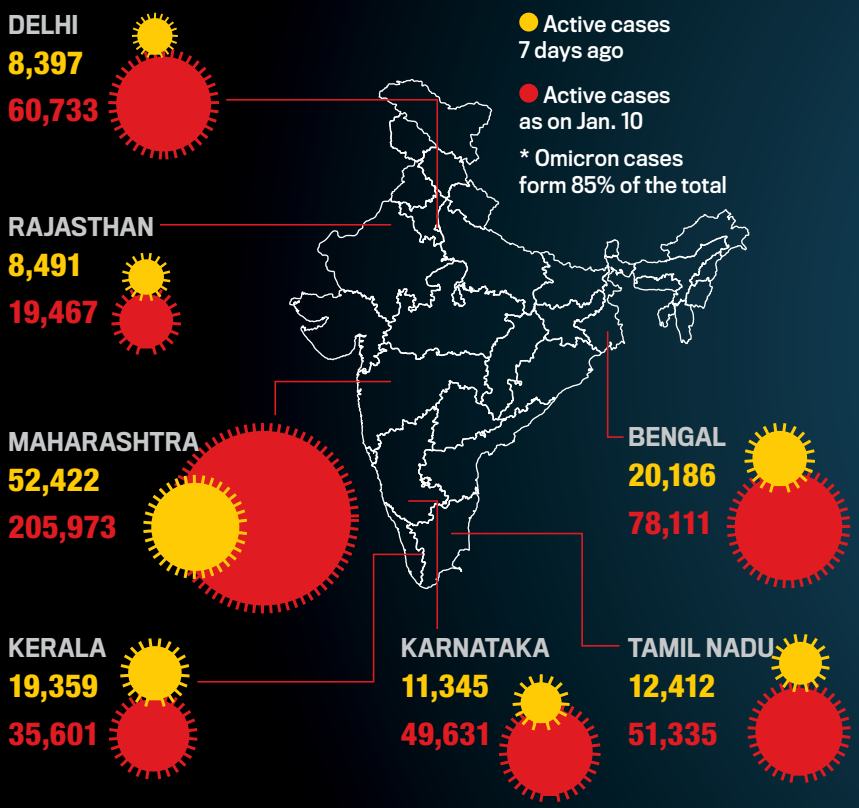
EMERGING STATES OF CONCERN



OMICRON IN MAHARASHTRA

Yet again, the state is seeing the maximum cases

SYMPTOMS

80-85% asymptomatic

HOSPITALISATION

5-10%, with an average stay of 3-4 days. Less than 1% require ICU care

BREAKTHROUGH INFECTIONS

81% had been vaccinated

DEATHS

None so far



Consider the facts. The Omicron variant was first identified in Botswana and South Africa in November 2021. Experts now acknowledge it as the fastest-spreading variant yet, responsible for the global resurgence of Covid, adding a daily caseload of 1.7 million. In India, it has spread four times faster than Delta (which was first discovered in India in December 2020) in the second wave. India's daily average of cases stood at 150,307 as on January 12, a number expected to quadruple in the coming weeks. According to central government sources, a genomic analysis of positive samples from across the country revealed Omicron's presence in 85 per cent samples and the Delta strain in the remaining. "There is no doubt that the upsurge we are witnessing in India is driven and powered by Omicron," asserts Dr V.K. Paul, member, NITI Aayog and chairman of the National Expert Group on Vaccine Administration for Covid-19 (NEGVAC). "It has dethroned Delta and is now the powerful new king of coronaviruses."

Dr Paul's declaration has ominous implications for the country. "The third wave is here," says Dr Randeep Guleria, chief of AIIMS, Delhi. "This doesn't mean we panic. We need to remedy the situation and double up on our containment efforts." On January 11, Dr Guleria took a booster dose of the Covid vaccine in the wake of the growing number of cases in the national capital where every fourth person being tested is Covid positive. The positivity rate of 25 per cent in Delhi is the highest since May 5, 2021, when Delta was wreaking havoc. As other metros like Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata began reporting a surge in cases, health officials in these cities reintroduced measures to slow down the spread, including weekend curfews and reimposing work-from-home norms. "There is need for zero complacency—masks, social distancing and testing are just the first line of defence," says Dr K. Srinath Reddy, chairman of the Delhi-based PHFI (Public Health Foundation of India).

> "THERE IS NO DOUBT THE CURRENT SURGE IS BEING DRIVEN BY OMICRON. IT HAS DETHRONED DELTA AS THE POWERFUL NEW KING OF CORONAVIRUSES"
>
> **DR V.K. PAUL**
> *Member, NITI Aayog*

IS OMICRON MORE INFECTIOUS THAN DELTA?

Omicron's most alarming trait is its infectivity. Of the two chief parameters used to assess the speed at which an infection spreads, Omicron is ahead of Delta on both. The first is the R-value or reproductive value of the virus, which is a measure of the number of people a single infected person can spread the virus to. Currently, this stands at 2.69 in India, more than double the 1.22 maximum R-value recorded during the Delta wave in 2021. The second in-